# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

The **Houthis**, Yemeni rebels backed by Iran, said they fired missiles at **Israel**, their first such attack since the Iran war began four weeks ago. Israel confirmed it had intercepted a missile from Yemen. The attack is an escalation in the war, but a limited one. The Houthis have not stepped up attacks on ships passing through the Red Sea, a trade chokepoint similar to the Strait of Hormuz, which is being blocked by Iran.

**Iran** struck **Saudi Arabia's** Prince Sultan Air Base, reportedly wounding 15 **American** troops, five of them seriously. Earlier Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, vowed to "exact a heavy price" for an Israeli attack on two Iranian nuclear facilities, which he insisted were civilian infrastructure. Donald Trump has repeatedly threatened and postponed American strikes on Iranian energy facilities. Steve Witkoff, Mr Trump's envoy, said he was "hopeful" of negotiations "this week".

The Republican-controlled House of Representatives passed a stop-gap bill to fund the **Department of Homeland Security**. The House earlier rejected a bipartisan measure, which had passed the Senate, to reopen the department, because it failed to fund immigration enforcement. The House's version is unlikely to pass

the Senate, leaving the six-week shutdown unresolved. Earlier Mr Trump directed DHS to pay airport-security staff.

**American stocks** wrapped up a wretched week. The S&P 500 share index lost nearly 1.7% of its value on Friday, putting it on course for its worst month in almost four years; the NASDAQ, a tech-heavy index, fell by more than 2.1%. Meanwhile the price of **Brent crude**, the global oil benchmark, rose to more than $112 a barrel.

Sixty-six members of the **World Trade Organisation**, including China and the EU, agreed to implement a digital-trade pact to make e-commerce easier and more secure. The participating countries, representing 70% of global trade, will adopt the arrangement among themselves. They bypassed dissenting countries, which argued that the dealmaking undermines the WTO's consensus principle—that something cannot be adopted into its framework if any of its 166 members object.

Nepal's former prime minister, **K.P. Sharma Oli**, was arrested for his involvement in the crackdown of youth-led protests—in which 70 people died—that toppled his government in September. Mr Oli has not been charged, but a panel recommended he be prosecuted for negligence. His lawyers called his arrest illegal. On Friday Balendra Shah, a 35-year-old former rapper, was sworn in as prime minister.

Four NASA astronauts began final preparations in Texas ahead of the first crewed journey towards the **Moon** since 1972. The mission (Artemis II), which will launch as early as April 1st, will send them on a ten-day loop around the Moon and back. America is racing China to put the next human on the Moon and ultimately to create a permanent lunar base.

**Word of the week:** Naxalites, a term for India's Maoist rebels, derived from Naxalbari, a village in West Bengal where their insurrection began in 1967. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

## The war’s fifth week brings a fork in the road

Saturday marks a month since America and Israel attacked Iran. The coming week could see ceasefire talks finally start in earnest. Or it could see ground forces enter the conflict for the first time.

On Thursday, Donald Trump extended his pause on attacking Iranian power plants—he says he has given Iran until April 6th to open the Strait of Hormuz. The actual state of negotiations is an enigma. Mr Trump says that talks are proceeding “very well.” Tehran denies they are taking place at all, despite Iranian media reporting that the regime rejected America’s 15-point peace plan and delivered its own counterproposals.

Meanwhile, more American troops have been arriving in the region, including rapid-response paratroopers, special-forces operatives and ships bearing units of marines. They could carry out a range of attacks, including on Iran’s oil terminals and its strongholds along the Strait. No one seems to know if America will escalate or negotiate—including its president.

Photograph: Alamy

## No Kings, and no wars

Over 3,000 “No Kings” demonstrations against Donald Trump are expected to take place across America on Saturday. Previous No Kings protests, held last June and October, were among the largest single-day demonstrations in American history. Organisers expect millions to show up waving signs and sporting colourful costumes. Protestors will have much to gripe about, not least Mr Trump’s hugely unpopular war in Iran.

The latest *Economist*/YouGov polling shows that approval for the president’s handling of the war stands at just 36%. Americans are especially worried about rising petrol prices. Though No Kings is mostly backed by left-leaning and progressive types, its organisers are hoping to capitalise on Mr Trump’s unpopularity to broaden their appeal. For Democrats, the protests will be an early indicator of voter mobilisation ahead of the midterms in November. Kings may despise the masses, but, as many find out, the people are hard to ignore.

Photograph: Courtesy of Art Basel

## Hong Kong’s complicated art market

With its international connections, trendy galleries and rich residents, Hong Kong has all the trappings of a thriving art market. But the city’s share of global auction sales fell from almost 24% in 2020 to 14.5% last year, according to a report by Mishcon de Reya and ArtTactic. Mainland China’s property crisis and tighter controls on capital outflows have made it harder for buyers to spend big. And a national-security law introduced in Hong Kong in 2020 quashed creative expression, scaring some artists away.

The art world will forget such woes, at least temporarily, when Hong Kong hosts Art Basel this weekend. The biggest and glitziest event in the city’s cultural calendar will host 240 galleries from around the world; last year’s event drew over 86,000 visitors. And on March 25th Hong Kong’s cultural minister announced that the city will hold the event’s Asia installment for another five years. It might not be time to rip up the canvas just yet.

Photograph: Alamy

## The rising stars of chess

Magnus Carlsen, a Norwegian grandmaster, once dominated chess. He became a world champion in 2013, defending his title four times before relinquishing it in 2023. Now he has been succeeded by Gukesh Dommaraju (pictured), who in 2024 was crowned the youngest world champion aged 18.

Who challenges Mr Dommaraju for his title next will be determined at the FIDE Candidates tournament, which begins in Cyprus on Saturday. The eight men gathering in the Mediterranean will play a gruelling double round-robin format, where each possible pair faces off twice. Half of the players are newcomers; only one, Fabiano Caruna, an Italian and American grandmaster, has contested a world championship before. And three are under the age of 25. One player to keep an eye on is 20-year-old Javokhir Sindarov from Uzbekistan, whose aggressive tactics have earned him a reputation for upsetting higher-ranked players. The next generation of chess players has arrived.

Photograph: Reuters

# Weekend profile: Marco Rubio, the chameleon in Trump's war room

A decade ago Marco Rubio predicted that a government led by Donald Trump would be "chaos". Both men were vying for the Republican presidential nomination. Mr Trump mocked Mr Rubio as "Little Marco".

These days, they are more polite. As Mr Trump's secretary of state, Mr Rubio is studiously deferential to his boss. Calm, articulate and competent, he lends coherence to Mr Trump's foreign policy. He is also the most prominent backer of the hawkish turn it has taken this year. If the current flurry of military adventurism ends well, Mr Rubio will be in a strong position to run again for president.

When Mr Rubio first ran for the Senate in 2010, he started 30 points behind his opponent, a sitting governor, but ended up winning easily. His pitch to voters was partly biographical. His Cuban parents had come to America with no English and no money. They worked hard for their children—his father as a bartender, his mother as a cashier. Mr Rubio, who at 38 was already speaker of the Florida House of Representatives, embodied the immigrant dream. He served for 14 years in the Senate, where he was well respected. In 2025 his peers confirmed him as secretary of state by a 99-0 vote.

To rise and thrive in Trumpworld, Mr Rubio has had to be both ruthless and chameleon-like. As a senator he was a leading advocate of bipartisan immigration reform and of arming Ukraine. Now he serves a master with a penchant for mass deportation and a soft spot for Vladimir Putin. Some doubt Mr Rubio's sincerity. Defenders say he restrains Mr Trump's excesses. European governments see him as one of the few administration officials they can deal with. That Mr Trump has gone quiet about seizing Greenland is, some say, thanks to Mr Rubio.

Mr Rubio's first trip abroad as secretary of state was to Central America and the Caribbean, to help stanch the flow of migrants and set the stage for confrontation with Venezuela. Next in his sights is Cuba; he has said the island needs not just new policies, but new leaders. In the Middle East, the pro-Israel Mr Rubio backed war with Iran. That puts him at the centre of the action—and more exposed if things go wrong.

For his part, Mr Rubio is playing down his ambitions. He says he will support J.D. Vance, the vice president, if he runs in 2028. But Mr Trump is unpopular; voters could pick a Democrat to succeed him. Mr Rubio might think it shrewder to let Mr Vance lose in 2028 and try his own luck in 2032. By that time America's mood may have shifted again. And Mr Rubio will no doubt adapt.

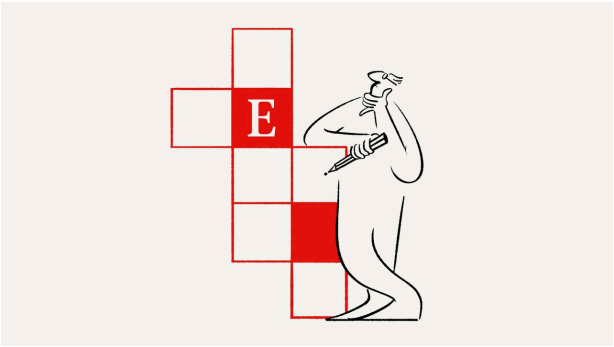


Illustration: The Economist

# Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

## Cryptic clues

*1 across* - Praise, in the Common Era, for chatbot (6)

*2 across* - Posh school got munched, I hear (4)

*3 across* - In an Asda, queues for tech-heavy stock index (6)

*1 down* - Drunken gasmen scorn man of the House (11)

## Straight clues

*1 across* - An AI chatbot developed by Anthropic (6)

*2 across* - Boarding school that has produced 20 British prime ministers (4)

*3 across* - American tech-heavy stock index (6)

*4 across* - A male member found inside the Beltway (11)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

# The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

**Rob Blair**, Harare Zimbabwe

**Wei Shi**, Espoo, Finland

**Brittany Logan**, Washington, DC, America

They all gave the correct answers of: Blue, honey, harvest festival, full house and Red Crescent. The theme is terms associated with the moon: Blue moon, honeymoon, harvest moon, full moon and crescent moon.

The questions were:

**Monday**: Which 1971 album by Joni Mitchell is often rated as one of the greatest of all time?

**Tuesday**: Clover, buckwheat and manuka are types of what food product?

**Wednesday**: What is the term for the annual celebration that occurs in many countries when the crops have been gathered?

**Thursday**: In poker, what is the term for a hand that contains three of a kind and a pair?

**Friday**: What is the name of the Islamic equivalent of the Red Cross?

*The only thing that saves us from the bureaucracy is inefficiency. An efficient bureaucracy is the greatest threat to liberty.*

---

***Eugene McCarthy***